that would march with him.[37] Never yet, in his decade's worth of reign, had Akbar led such a large force; nor, indeed, faced one. Even Hemu had only 1500 elephants, at most, in Panipat; but Akbar was taking no chances against the very men who fought that battle for him. Could it be that the Uzbeks who had marched into Hindustan with Humayun would snatch the realm from his son, turn him into just another fief-holder among raucous, rival commanders, just another zamindar in a land full of petty kings?

No, Akbar was taking no chances. On 24 May 1565, Akbar rode out of Agra, having given yet another, more secret, order. Mirza Abul Qasim, Akbar's cousin and Kamran's son, had lived in shadow his whole life and in the dungeons of Gwalior these past years. He was to be killed.

It is popularly held that the shedding of family blood among Babur's descendants began with Shahjahan – Akbar's grandson – who had all his male relatives killed when he took the throne. To find Akbar killing his cousin, too, comes as a bit of a shock; even more since it follows Humayun's tearfully held resolve to spare this very Abul Qasim's father, the far more threatening Kamran, again and again.[38] Akbar himself was not keen to publicize his decision – it is not recorded by any contemporary chronicler; not Abul Fazl, not even Badauni, who rarely misses a chance to condemn his king. Many later historians, however, agree that Akbar's departure from Agra was also the time of his cousin's demise – there was the risk, no matter how remote, that Abul Qasim would become the Uzbeks' figurehead, giving their revolt its cause.[39]

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Thus unencumbered by his inconvenient cousin, Akbar set off. The burning north Indian summer had begun, so the army marched at night – one can only imagine the scene, the dark silhouettes of 2000 elephants, troops upon troops of cavalry, the endless thud of feet and hooves, the drumbeats to guide the way, the burning torches held up in pitch darkness. When they reached the Ganga, Akbar was gripped by a familiar impatience. It would take ten days for the whole army to cross the river, but Sikander Khan Uzbek was close by, it was said, in Lucknow, seemingly unperturbed by the imperial advance. Akbar took a few men and 'at midnight went off on horseback'.[40] Sikander fled at news of his furious approach.